

Beyond the Conduct Code

by Sophia



WHAT'S COVERED

In this lesson, you will learn about “unwritten” rules of conduct; though not binding legal obligations, they are standards of ethical behavior employees should observe. Specifically, this lesson will cover:

1. Getting Along With Coworkers

While the code of conduct at work may stand as a written document to guide our behaviors, much like a driver’s manual might cover the rules of the road, we can recognize there are more “codes” or “norms” or “customs” at work (or while driving) than any code of conduct (or manual) might contain. There are “unwritten rules” of decorum and civility in every workplace, physical or remote. Who speaks when, who goes first, and “how things get done around here” are often examples of these unwritten rules.

It’s important to note that many codes of conduct state they are the minimal or minimum standards; less is not acceptable and is cause for termination. This emphasis on “these are the basic requirements or rules of conduct” also tells us they represent a foundation to guide our conduct, but that there are many more “rules” to learn on the job, in action, as we learn the ropes and observe how others interact, and what they expect of themselves and others.

An employee who gets along with coworkers can help the company perform better. What can employees do to help create a more harmonious workplace with a positive atmosphere?



Ethical obligations to your employer and coworkers go beyond daily tasks and even the office building, such as showing empathy for colleagues, pitching in when help is needed, and not complaining publicly (online or offline) about the company or coworkers.

One thing you can do is to keep an open mind. You may be wondering as you start a new job whether you will get along with your colleagues as well as you did at your old job. Or, if you did not get along with the people there and were looking for a change, you might fear things will be the same at the new job. Do not make any prejudgments. Get to know a bit about your new coworkers. Accept, or extend, lunch invitations, join weekend activities and office social events, and perhaps join those office traditions that bind long-serving employees and newcomers together in a collaborative spirit.

Another thing you can do is to remember to be kind. Everyone has a bad day every now and then, and if you spot a coworker having one, performing a random act of kindness may make that person's day better. You do not need to be extravagant. Offer to stay late to help the person meet a tight deadline or bring coffee or a healthy snack to someone working on particularly difficult tasks. Remember the adage, "It's nice to be important, but it's more important to be nice."

For any relationship to succeed, including the relationship between coworkers, the parties must respect each other—and show it. Avoid doing things that might offend others. For example, do not take credit for someone else's work. Do not be narrow-minded; when someone brings up a topic such as politics or religion, be willing to listen and tolerate differing points of view.

A related directive is to avoid sexual jokes, stories, anecdotes, and innuendos. You might think it is okay to talk about anything and everything at work, but it is not. Others may not find the topic funny and feel offended, and you may make yourself vulnerable to action by management if such behavior is reported. Your coworkers

might be a captive audience, but you should never place them in an awkward position.

Make an effort to get along with everyone, even difficult people. You did not choose your coworkers, and some may be hard to get along with. But professionalism requires that we attempt to establish the best working relationships we can on the job, no matter the opinions we might have about our colleagues. Normally, we might like some of them very much, be neutral about some others, and genuinely dislike others. Yet our responsibility in the workplace is to respect and act at least civilly toward all of them. We likely will feel better about ourselves as professionals and also live up to our commitments to our companies.

Finally, do not use social media to gossip about work. Even if you don't violate the code of conduct by disparaging the company, complaining about colleagues can damage morale. It makes you appear petty, small, and untrustworthy, and colleagues may stop communicating with you.



There is a key exception to this rule when illegal activity is taking place, and you do have an ethical obligation to tell the appropriate authorities. You will learn more about the proper way to do that in an upcoming tutorial on whistleblowing.



It is normal for people to commiserate about frustrations at work, and that might include colleagues! Perhaps you've done so, or (perhaps worse) discovered that you were the subject of less-than-flattering conversations.

Where do these conversations cross the line into unethical behavior?



One place to start is the Golden Rule. How would you want to be treated? If you do not want people to talk about you, then you should not talk about them in an unflattering way. It can be tempting to try and be a part of the crowd and go along with saying negative things about people, but this is never a good idea. It does not bring positivity to the workplace.

If something negative is said about someone that isn't present, it is probably unethical.

How can you steer conversations away from unfair treatment of others?



One way to handle a situation where conversation starts being unfairly critical of someone is to say, "Well, everyone has their quirks" (or something similar), and change the subject.

What would you do if you received an e-mail that disparaged a colleague?



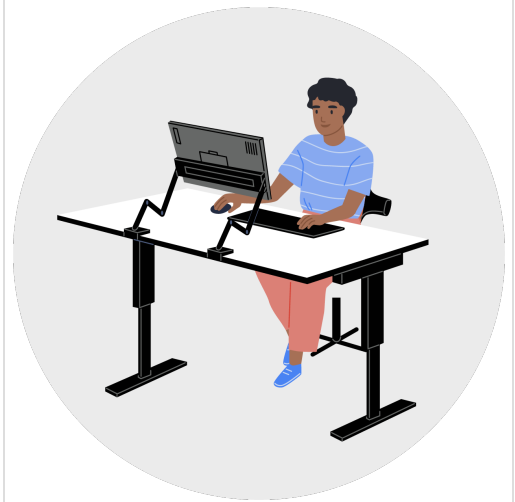
Speaking badly about people should never, ever happen in writing. People have even been fired for this when an e-mail message or text states negative things about colleagues, the company, or the organization. In this case, you may go beyond a gentle redirection and remind the person that a written record of abuse can be a liability for themselves and the company.

The main thing to consider here is to treat others how you want to be treated—and if you don't want people to talk about you, then don't talk about them.

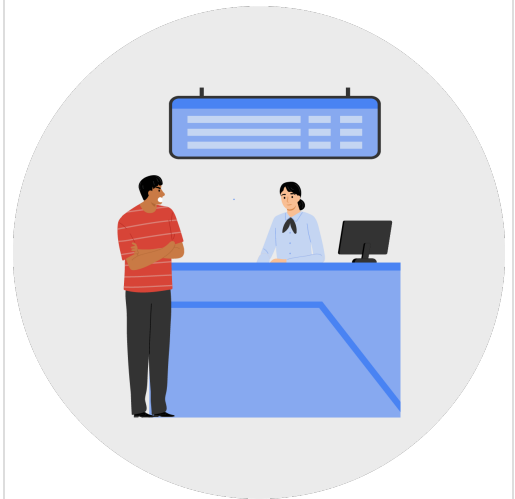
2. Emotional Intelligence

Understanding the various personalities at work can be a complex task, but it is a vital one for developing a sense of collegiality. One technique that may be helpful is to develop your own **emotional intelligence**, the ability to control your own emotions, while understanding and responding to the way other people feel. Emotional intelligence includes five areas: internal motivation, self-regulation, self-awareness, empathy, and social awareness.

Internal (or intrinsic) motivation refers to your own ability to get work done without needing external motivation from others, such as a boss. For example, a person with high internal motivation is able to get things done and may effectively use “to do” lists and calendars.



Self-regulation is the ability to manage your emotions. For example, if you are really angry, you would control your anger and, for example, take a break before speaking with someone about an issue.



Self-awareness is the ability to evaluate yourself on an ongoing basis and understand how your actions or behavior impact others. In addition, high self-awareness means you likely know your strengths and weaknesses.



Empathy refers to your ability to understand how others feel. This aspect of emotional intelligence is important, because it allows us to put ourselves in another's shoes and better understand how they may be feeling, and take necessary action.



Social awareness refers to how you interact with others, pick up on social cues, and an ability to “read the room.” Usually, people with high social awareness are good listeners and are able to fit in by understanding how they fit into a social situation.



These emotional intelligence factors are important to business ethics because higher emotional intelligence means we likely attempt to understand others and think before we act.

HINT

Based on your upbringing, past experiences, and innate psychology, self-regulation may come naturally or take special effort. There are a number of resources available, as well as classes where you can learn and practice strategies. Three broad strategies with research-proven results are the following:

- Mindfulness (staying in the here and now)
- Cognitive Reappraisal (being aware of personal triggers and how to handle them)
- Emotional Suppression (being able to delay, but not ignore, an emotional response)

Besides helping you behave more ethically and effectively, these can also bring peace of mind (Whelan, 2022).

TERMS TO KNOW

Emotional Intelligence

The ability to control your own emotions, while understanding and responding to the way other people feel.

Self-Regulation

The ability to manage your emotions.

Self-Awareness

Self-Awareness

The ability to evaluate yourself on an ongoing basis and understand how your actions or behavior impact others. Also, a good understanding of your own strengths and weaknesses.

Empathy

Your ability to understand how others feel.

Social Awareness

How you interact with others and pick up on social cues; an ability to “read the room.” Usually, people with high social awareness are good listeners and are able to fit in by understanding how they fit into a social situation.

3. Understanding Personalities

All of us have different **workplace personalities**, which express the way we think and act on the job. There are many such personalities, and none is superior or inferior to another, but they are a way in which we exhibit our uniqueness on the job. Some of us lead with our brains and emphasize logic and reason. Others lead with their hearts, always emphasizing mercy over justice in their relationships with others.



HINT

You can find online personality tests if you want to learn more about your personality and work style. Some may be more reliable than others, and no online test will be as reliable as a controlled personality test, but it might be fun and instructive if you have never taken one before. Here is one:

www.scienceofpeople.com/personality/

Employees can also have very different **work styles**, the way in which we are most comfortable accomplishing our tasks at work. Some of us gravitate toward independence and jobs or tasks we can accomplish alone. Others prefer team or project work, bringing them into touch with different personalities. Still others seek a mix of these environments. Some prioritize getting the job done as efficiently as possible, whereas others value the journey of working on the project with others and the shared experiences it brings. There is no right or wrong style, but it benefits any worker to know their preferences and something about the work personalities of colleagues. When in the office, the point for any of us individually is to appreciate what motivates our greatest success and happiness on the job.



THINK ABOUT IT

Imagine you are a department director with two employees reporting directly to you. You like and respect them individually, as do the others in your department, but they simply cannot get along and don't like to work together. They have personalities that don't mesh. Jay likes to make jokes and indulge in small talk. Kay is quite serious and doesn't like to go off topic in meetings or waste time. Another problem is work styles. Kay is conscientious and likes to work out a plan, assign tasks to each member of the team, and then wants everyone to “stay in their lanes.” Jay is a lot more flexible, preferring to “make it up as he goes,” but it does not affect the quality of his work. Both of them do excellent work; the only problem is working together. You need them to work together on an upcoming project.

How do you resolve this personality clash?



While you may not be able to fully solve this clash, there are a few things you might consider before putting them on a project together to minimize this clash.

- Consider having your whole team take a work styles and personality test and have open

conversations about how to best work with each style.

- Get Kay and Jay together to openly discuss their differences and come to a middle ground. For example, perhaps Kay is able to assign tasks, but Jay is allowed to determine how things actually get done. Perhaps Kay can agree to engaging in more personable small talk by setting aside 10 minutes every meeting for this activity.
- You could speak with them individually and address the issues, asking them to be patient with the other personality type.
- You could put one or the other “in charge” of the project, so that person’s style will prevail, and they will have the power to leverage their preferred style.
- There is always the option to do nothing. Assuming they are both professionals, the hope here is that they will be able to figure it out together.



TERMS TO KNOW

Workplace Personality

The manner in which we think and act on the job.

Work Style

The way in which we are most comfortable accomplishing our tasks at work.

4. Managing Conflict

Personality conflicts are one thing, but what about outright conflict? The word “conflict” produces a sense of anxiety for many people, but it is part of the human experience. Just because conflict is universal does not mean that we cannot improve how we handle disagreements, misunderstandings, and struggles to understand or make ourselves understood. In terms of business ethics, it is important to minimize conflict that is disruptive, but not to simply suppress it.

When incompatible goals, scarce resources, or interference are present, conflict is a typical result, but it doesn’t mean the relationship is poor or failing. All relationships progress through times of conflict and collaboration. How we navigate and negotiate these challenges influences, reinforces, or destroys the relationship. Conflict is universal, but how and when it occurs is open to influence and interpretation. Rather than viewing conflict from a negative frame of reference, view it as an opportunity for clarification, growth, and even reinforcement of the relationship (Saylor Academy, 2012). How to manage conflict constructively is a learned skill, but one that will prove valuable throughout your career and can make you an ethical leader. Check with your human resources department about training opportunities within your organization or to see if reimbursement is available for training sought outside of the organization.



SUMMARY

In this lesson, you learned that ethical obligations at work are not limited to the code of conduct, which outlines minimal standards for behavior. These obligations include **getting along with coworkers**, especially being able to work with people who have different cultures or personalities. **Understanding personalities** can go a long way in helping understand people (even from the same culture) who have different work and communication styles. **Managing conflict** well is another

obligation, which may take special training. Conflict can be a source of stress at work, but if well managed, can also be a source of strength.

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TERMS TO KNOW

Emotional Intelligence

The ability to control your own emotions, while understanding and responding to the way other people feel.

Empathy

Your ability to understand how others feel.

Self-Awareness

The ability to evaluate yourself on an ongoing basis and understand how your actions or behavior impact others. Also, a good understanding of your own strengths and weaknesses.

Self-Regulation

The ability to manage your emotions.

Social Awareness

How you interact with others and pick up on social cues; an ability to “read the room.” Usually, people with high social awareness are good listeners and are able to fit in by understanding how they fit into a social situation.

Work Style

The way in which we are most comfortable accomplishing our tasks at work.

Workplace Personality

The manner in which we think and act on the job.